Khrushchev was alerted to the imminent American deployment of the Minuteman and Soviet inability to respond effectively at a meeting of his Defense Council held at the Pitsunda resort on the Black Sea in February 1962. According to Khrushchev's son Sergei, a young missile engineer who attended the meeting, the bad news was delivered to the first secretary by Marshal Moskalenko. Khrushchev trusted the marshal, a native of the Donbas region of Ukraine, where Khrushchev had long lived and worked. In June 1953 Moskalenko had shown his loyalty to Khrushchev by leading the group of officers who arrested Khrushchev's archenemy Lavrentii Beria. Four years later, in July 1957, when the party Presidium tried to oust Khrushchev, Moskalenko had helped to convene a plenum of the Central Committee, which exonerated Khrushchev and removed his opponents from leadership positions. It was on Moskalenko's watch that the Soviets put Yurii Gagarin into orbit in April 1961 and exploded the Tsar Bomba in October of the same year. But with the Americans ready to deploy the Minuteman, Moskalenko ran out of luck.[7]

Moskalenko began his report on a positive note: starting that year, the army would get a new intercontinental ballistic missile, the R-16 (SS-7 Sadler in US classification). A 30-meter-long missile weighing 140 metric tons, it could deliver a 5-megaton nuclear warhead at a distance of up to 11,000 kilometers, well in excess of the 8,000 kilometers that separated Moscow from Washington. The news that the R-16 missiles were ready for deployment had special meaning for Moskalenko and all those in the room. In October 1960, one of the earlier versions of that missile had exploded on the launchpad at the Baikonur test range in Kazakhstan, killing ninety-two people, including Moskalenko's predecessor, the first commander of the Soviet Strategic Missile Forces, Marshal Mitrofan Nedelin. The first successful launch of the R-16 from a silo took place in January 1962. The missile was now ready for deployment.[8]

But that was all the good news Moskalenko could deliver. He had to admit that the long-awaited R-16 was no match for the Minuteman. It was the first Soviet rocket to use storable liquid fuel, which reduced the preparation time for launching, but even so, fueling the two stages took hours—up to six hours, according to Moskalenko. Preparation time for the Minuteman, he reported, was only a few minutes. "While we bring it out